



The Apostolic Preaching by C. H. Dodd

Review by: Ernest W. Parsons

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Professor Colwell's arraignment of the "modernizing" type of interpretation is just and indisputable. While we are wary of the implications of his term, we agree in the main with him in the snares and weaknesses which he points out.

The two chapters on the historical method present clear and valid distinctions and are calculated to be greatly helpful to the Bible student, even though they contain some conclusions with which many of us do not find ourselves able to agree. For instance, we are unable to consider the apocryphal gospels of the infancy as merely a more advanced development of the process which produced the canonical gospels (p. 158). We believe they represent an entirely different sort of development. However, this is only a difference of opinion as to conclusions reached in the application of the historical method; as to the merits and significance of the method itself, we agree with Professor Colwell.

One of the best features of the book is the well-selected bibliographies. However, we feel that the principles of selection have been too narrowly restricted. In the bibliography on text transmission one misses such names as Warfield and Robertson beside those of Kenyon and Lake. Especially does one miss the name of A. T. Robertson from the list of grammars on pages 98 f., and that of Thayer from the list of lexicons.

Anyone who may wish to acquire a sane understanding of the Christian scriptures, based upon fact rather than fancy, needs to give careful consideration to the matters discussed in this book.

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The Apostolic Preaching. By C. H. DODD. Chicago: Willett, Clark, 1937. x+167 pages. \$1.50.

The volume under review is a small book, but there is much in it. In an attempt to do "synthetic interpretation" and thus "to discover the unity which underlies the diversity of New Testament thought," the author approaches the understanding of the New Testament and the early Christian movement from the standpoint of its spoken message, its preaching, or, as he constantly calls it, its "kerygma." In the first of three lectures he seeks to discover, by means of an examination of the Pauline letters and certain sections of the Acts of the Apostles, the content of the primitive Christian message. On the whole, this is very well done, and the main results are not open to much valid criticism.

The Pauline message consists of the following elements. (1) The proph-

ecies are fulfilled, and the new age is inaugurated by the coming of Christ. (2) He was born of the seed of David. (3) He died according to the scriptures, to deliver us out of the present evil age. (4) He was buried. (5) He rose on the third day, according to the scriptures. (6) He is exalted at the right hand of God as Son of God and Lord of quick and dead. (7) He will come again as judge and savior of men. Other elements there were, but these are the chief ones that are recoverable. The Jerusalem preaching is substantially the same, the principal exceptions being that it does not call Jesus the Son of God, it does not assert that Jesus died for our sins, and it does not assert that the exalted Messiah intercedes for us.

Turning to an interpretation of this primitive message, Professor Dodd calls attention to the sense of immediacy which pervades it. It is not an event of the future, this coming of the kingdom—not even of the very early future—but something that has “already entered history,” that has already happened. The new age is already here, and the moral and spiritual transformation implied in the term “repent” is not a condition of sharing in its blessings but is a duty because the kingdom has already come. The proof of its presence is found in the possession of the Spirit. The writer strongly emphasizes the position that the early Christians considered that the “eschaton” has happened and that the return of the Messiah is implied but not emphasized in the preaching.

A second lecture ostensibly examines the gospels, but other parts of the New Testament are used in the consideration of the contribution of this section to the general problem. The conclusion is that, in view of the “unexpected delay in the consummation,” the “church proceeded to reconstruct on a modified plan the traditional scheme of Jewish eschatology which had been broken up by the declaration that the kingdom of God had already come.” Instances of this procedure are seen in the second chapter of II Thessalonians, in the “little apocalypse” of Mark, and in other parts of the Synoptic Gospels. The Revelation of John is an outstanding example of this “futurist” tendency. But this “futurist” tendency was in danger of “leading into a blind alley,” as, indeed, it did somewhat later. To offset this danger of futility another process, really a recrudescence of the primitive view of a “realized eschatology,” led to a “concentration of attention upon the historical facts of the ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus, exhibited in an eschatological setting which made clear their absolute and final quality as saving facts.” This interpretation is traced through Paul and Hebrews and I Peter, and especially through Mark.

A third lecture returns to the primitive kerygma, with special attention to that part of it which attributed an eschatological significance to

facts of the present. The outcome of this lecture is to show that the Pauline ethico-mysticism is but a transformation of eschatology, although the author uses the term "Christ-mysticism." It is interesting to note that the chief quoted support for this view is drawn from Ephesians. It is, however, in the Fourth Gospel that this refining transformation of eschatology reaches its climax. While Paul considers little but the death and resurrection of Jesus, the Fourth Gospel reinterprets the whole life of Jesus and unites two strains of Christian thought, "that which started from an eschatological valuation of the facts of present experience and that which started from a similar valuation of the facts of past history." In this reinterpretation Professor Dodd finds a close relationship to the apostolic kerygma. The conclusions derived by the author from the survey are that there is a striking variety in the New Testament interpretations of the kerygma and that, in all these interpretations, the essential elements of the original message are persistently kept in view. An appendix, under the title "Eschatology and History," closes the book. So far as primitive Christianity is concerned, this chapter adds little to the positions already taken.

There are many details in this book with which the reviewer finds himself in agreement. Nevertheless, the main positions seem to be based upon too academic and too artificial a framework. While there are expressions and passages in the New Testament which speak of the eschatological salvation as in some way present, they seem to fall short of the "realized eschatology" of our writer's thought. Proleptic utterances and the language of enthusiasm are construed as expressions of reflective interpretation. The future element, even if the future is not a long one, of the primitive preaching is a more important one than the author seems to consider it. Specific statements, such as "the times of the restoration of all things," merit a more important place than they receive. The personal religious experience of Paul played a larger role in the development of his ethico-mysticism than a desire or a need for an adjustment of eschatological hopes. In the framework of his thinking there is a difference between justification and salvation. This latter remains in an essential sense a future matter. The reviewer doubts whether there is any definite chronological sequence between the allegedly earlier eschatological outlook and the later mystical experience of the apostle. They are two aspects of his entire redemptive thought. There is much more in the essential thought of the Fourth Gospel than can be pressed into the mold of a modified eschatology. The modified eschatology is there, but not in such a dominating position as the author seems to think.

It may be desirable to endeavor to discover an underlying unity be-

neath the manifestly varied thought and expression of the New Testament documents, but the writer of this review wishes to move very cautiously in that direction. In any case, he doubts that the thought movements of Christianity in the New Testament age can be interpreted by means of so rigid and simple a pattern as the author suggests. One almost wishes it could be done, for it would so greatly simplify the task of the New Testament historian. The book is provocative of thought; it is challenging in many of its findings; it is frequently brilliant in its insights; but it leaves the reader not quite convinced.

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Mind and the Mystery. By C. J. EUSTACE. New York: Longmans, Green, 1937. xx+314 pages. \$2.50.

This a Catholic book which Protestants should read since it is an attempt to interpret Thomism, the reigning Catholic philosophy, to them. Although the specific problem to which the author addresses himself is that of the place, object, and function of mind, he cannot solve it adequately until he has presented the Thomistic evaluation of philosophy, theology, science, revelation, scripture, tradition, and the church.

The mystery of which the author writes has to do with "the inner core of things, unseen, intangible, but nevertheless making them what they are" (p. 11). This he interprets to be God; and the problem is how much mind, in its various pursuits (philosophy, science, and, to some extent, theology) can tell us about God or the ultimate nature of things.

The author affirms the traditional Catholic division between faith and reason and, quite naturally, winds up with the familiar scholastic division of labor between revealed and rational truths. The extraordinary social pressure of the modern world is nowhere more evident than in his attempt to create a third category of truths, namely, those dealing with "positive precepts concerning morals, the worship of God, and such things" (p. 261). Manifestly, there is no logical warrant for this category, because such truths are either revealed or rational or no truths at all.

Mind deals with objective reality under three degrees of abstraction. Natural science perceives and catalogues the sensory or material attributes of an object and has an "experimental constancy" in that the object is what it is and can be used as the basis for checking theories and discrepancies. This is first-degree abstraction in that its attempt to know the object does not take it beyond the concrete reality of the individual with which it deals. However, science, in order to predict successfully